

Ciela

User Guide

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Your email stays on your computer.
No cloud. No accounts. No ads. No subscriptions.

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1 Welcome to Ciela

Ciela is a free desktop application that helps you clean up your email inbox. It connects to Gmail and Outlook via secure sign-in, and to iCloud, Yahoo, Zoho Mail, AOL, Fastmail, and thirty or more other email providers using IMAP — the standard connection method used by most email services outside of Gmail and Outlook. Every scan runs entirely on your own computer — Ciela classifies your emails into twenty-one categories and gives you the tools to remove years of unwanted mail in a few clicks.

Everything happens on your device. Ciela never sends your email — or any information about your email — to any server. The only network traffic is between your computer and your email provider's own servers.

1.1 What Ciela does

- Connects to Gmail and Outlook with a one-click sign-in, and to iCloud, Yahoo, and other providers with a simple email-and-password form
- Reads only the **sender**, **subject line**, and unsubscribe link of each email — never the full content or attachments
- Groups your senders into twenty-one categories so you can see at a glance what is filling your inbox
- Separates senders who send multiple types of email — for example, a retailer's receipts and marketing appear as distinct rows so you can clean one without touching the other
- Lets you move all emails from a sender row to Trash in one click, with an optional date filter to protect recent messages
- Remembers your scan results between sessions — your inbox list reappears immediately the next time you open Ciela
- Supports multiple connected accounts — switch between inboxes in one click

1.2 What Ciela does not do

- Read, store, or transmit your email content
- Permanently delete email — everything goes to your provider's Trash folder, where it stays for 30 days before being removed automatically
- Run in the background or send you notifications
- Require you to create an account or pay a subscription

2 Before You Begin

2.1 System requirements

- **Operating system:** Windows 10/11, macOS 12 or later, or Linux (AppImage)
- **Internet connection:** Required during the scan (to fetch from your provider) and during sign-in
- **Email account:** Gmail, Outlook/Hotmail/Microsoft 365, or any IMAP-compatible provider

3 Connecting Your Account

When you open Ciela for the first time, the connect screen offers three paths: Gmail, Outlook, and IMAP. **Not sure which is yours?** If your email address ends in gmail.com, choose Gmail. If it ends in outlook.com, hotmail.com, or live.com, choose Outlook. For icloud.com, yahoo.com, aol.com, zoho.com, fastmail.com, or any other address, choose IMAP. You can connect multiple accounts — add more at any time from Settings.

3.1 Gmail

- 1 Click **Connect Gmail**. A browser tab will open showing Google's standard sign-in page.
- 2 Sign in with your Gmail account and click **Allow** when Google asks for permission.
- 3 The browser tab will close automatically, and Ciela will begin scanning your inbox.

Ciela remembers your sign-in between sessions. The next time you open the app, you will go straight to your inbox list without signing in again.

If your browser does not open automatically, check that a default browser is set in your system settings. Ciela uses your system browser for security — embedded browser windows are prohibited by Google's OAuth policy.

3.2 Outlook

- 1 Click **Connect Outlook**. A browser tab will open showing Microsoft's standard sign-in page.
- 2 Sign in with your Microsoft account and approve the permission request.
- 3 The browser tab will close automatically, and Ciela will begin scanning your inbox.

Outlook, Hotmail, Live, and Microsoft 365 work accounts are all supported. If you have a personal @outlook.com or @hotmail.com address, choose Outlook.

3.3 IMAP (iCloud, Yahoo, Zoho Mail, and 30+ providers)

IMAP providers require an **app password** — a separate password generated specifically for Ciela, different from your main account password. This is a security requirement from the provider, not Ciela. Here is how to generate one for the most common providers:

iCloud: Sign in to appleid.apple.com → Sign-In and Security → App-Specific Passwords → click +. You must have two-factor authentication enabled on your Apple ID first. If you do not see this option, enable two-factor authentication in your Apple ID settings and then come back.

Yahoo: Sign in to Yahoo Mail → click your name in the top right → Account Security → Generate app password → select “Other app” → type “Ciela” → Generate.

AOL: Sign in to your AOL account → Account Security → scroll to “Generate app password.”

Other providers: Look in your account’s Security or Mail settings for “App passwords” or “Third-party access.”

Zoho Mail: IMAP access is disabled by default in Zoho. Before connecting, sign in to Zoho Mail in your browser → Settings → Mail Accounts → IMAP Access → Enable.

- 1 On the connect screen, choose your provider from the list (iCloud, Yahoo, Zoho Mail, AOL, Fastmail, and many others).
- 2 Enter your email address.
- 3 Enter your **app password** (generated using the instructions above).
- 4 Click **Connect**. Ciela tests the connection immediately. If the credentials are correct, your inbox list will open. If there is a problem, a plain-language error message will describe what went wrong.

App passwords are stored securely. Ciela saves your app password in your operating system’s credential vault — Windows Credential Manager, macOS Keychain, or Linux Secret Service. It is never written to a plain text file on disk and is erased from memory immediately after each use.

If your provider is not in the list, choose **Other** and enter the IMAP hostname and port manually.

4 Your First Scan

After connecting, Ciela immediately begins scanning your inbox. Depending on how many emails you have and which provider you use, this can take anywhere from a few minutes to over an hour.

A mailbox with 50,000 emails typically takes 20–30 minutes on a first scan over Gmail or Outlook. IMAP scans tend to be slower — expect 30–60 minutes for a large IMAP mailbox due to protocol limitations. After your first scan, subsequent scans only check for new mail since your last visit and complete in seconds to a few minutes.

4.1 What you will see during the scan

While scanning, Ciela shows you:

- A **progress bar** with the number of messages scanned and an estimated percentage complete
- A **live category breakdown** that updates in real time as emails are classified
- **Rotating tips** about how to get the most out of Ciela

The scan can be safely interrupted at any time — just close the app. When you reopen Ciela, the scan will resume from where it left off rather than starting over.

5 The Dashboard

When the scan completes, Ciela opens the **Dashboard** — a summary of what is in your inbox.

5.1 Category overview

The main panel shows one card per category, with the number of emails and senders for each. Click any card to open a filtered sender list for that category.

5.2 Dormant Subscriptions

Below the category overview, Ciela lists newsletters you have not opened in five or more months. Each entry shows the sender and an **Unsubscribe** button that opens the stored unsubscribe link in your browser. Ciela tracks whether the sender actually stops emailing after you click Unsubscribe, and reports back as “Confirmed ✓” or “Still sending.”

5.3 Inbox History

The **Inbox History** chart shows a bar for each calendar year your inbox contains email — from the oldest message to the present. Taller bars mean more email received that year. The chart refreshes after every full scan.

The Inbox History chart appears after your first complete scan. It will not be visible until a full scan has finished.

6 Understanding Your Results

When the scan finishes, you will see a list of every sender in your inbox, sorted from most emails to fewest.

6.1 Reading a sender row

Each row in the list shows:

- **Sender name** — the display name the sender uses
- **Email address** — the actual address emails came from
- **Category badge** — a coloured label showing how Ciela classified this email type
- **Email count** — how many emails of this type are in your inbox
- **Trash button** — to move this category of emails from this sender to Trash

Senders who send multiple types of email appear as separate rows — one per category. For example, a retailer that sends both order confirmations and promotional offers will appear as two rows: **Receipts** and **Active Marketing**. You can trash the marketing while keeping every receipt untouched.

6.2 Navigating by category

The left panel shows all twenty-one categories. Click any category name to filter the sender list to that group.

6.3 Correcting a category

If Ciela has placed a sender in the wrong category, click the **category badge** next to the sender name. The badge is replaced by an inline dropdown showing all categories — select the correct one and Ciela immediately moves the sender to the right place. Future scans will keep the sender in the category you chose.

After you reclassify a sender, Ciela looks for other senders that share the same email domain. If any are found, a panel appears listing them — tick the ones you want to move, click **Apply**, and they are all reclassified at once.

6.4 The twenty-one categories

Ciela assigns every sender to one of the following categories:

Category	What it contains
Personal	Emails from real people using personal email services
Security	Login alerts, verification codes, password resets, and two-step sign-in messages
Government	Federal, state, and local government agencies; .gov domains

Category	What it contains
Finance	Bank statements, invoices, receipts, tax documents, and investment notifications
Utilities	Electric, gas, water, internet, and phone providers
Travel	Flight bookings, hotel reservations, itineraries, and boarding passes
Receipts	Order confirmations, shipping updates, delivery notifications, and refunds
Notifications	App alerts, activity digests, reminders, and automated summaries
Education	Schools, universities, and learning platforms — Canvas, Blackboard, school districts, and similar
Healthcare	Patient portals, appointment reminders, pharmacy notifications, and medical office communications
Food	Food delivery (DoorDash, Uber Eats, Grubhub), restaurant loyalty programs, and meal kits
Subscription	Newsletters and curated email publications you have subscribed to
Jobs	Recruiters, job boards, staffing agencies, and application updates
Dating	Dating app notifications and match alerts
Faith	Religious organisations, places of worship, and faith-based charities
Real Estate	Listings, agent updates, mortgage notifications, and rental platforms
Gaming	Game launchers, in-game alerts, and esports
Gambling	Casinos, sports betting, and lottery
Active Marketing	Promotional emails from companies that are actively sending to you
Dead Marketing	Promotional emails from senders who have not mailed in years — often the safest to clean up
Unknown	Senders Ciela could not confidently classify — review these and reclassify where needed

Classification is done locally on your computer using a set of rules. It is very accurate for bulk mail and personal email. Occasionally a transactional email may be classified as a notification or vice versa — use your own judgement when reviewing.

6.5 Sender detail

Click a sender's **display name** to open the sender detail screen, loaded instantly from your local database with no network connection required.

6.5.1 What you will see

- **Last opened blurb** — “You last opened an email from this sender X ago”, or a note if you have never opened one

- **Stats row** — total emails, unread count, open rate percentage, and the date of the first and last email from this sender
- **Frequency** — how many emails this sender sends per month on average
- **Volume gauge** — a five-bar signal gauge labelled Cold, Cool, Warm, Hot, or Flood

Level	Rate	What it means
Cold	< 1 per year	A rare sender — a one-off or very old contact
Cool	1–3 per month	Occasional sender — newsletters, infrequent alerts
Warm	4–14 per month	Regular sender — weekly newsletters, app notifications
Hot	15–49 per month	Frequent sender — daily digests, active marketing
Flood	50+ per month	Very high volume — likely a heavy promotional sender

- **Engagement chart** — vertical bars for each calendar year, showing total received (grey) vs. opened (green)
- **Subject list** — up to 500 recent messages, newest first, with date and subject line; unread messages shown in bold with a green dot

6.5.2 Actions from the detail screen

- **Unsubscribe** — opens the sender's unsubscribe link in your browser (only shown if Ciela found one)
- **Protect** — marks the sender as protected; excluded from all bulk operations until you remove the protection
- **Category badge** — click to reclassify the sender inline
- **Sort & protect** — opens a checklist of every email type this sender has sent you; keep what you want, trash the rest in one step (see Section 7)
- **Move to Trash** — moves all emails from this sender to Trash

7 Cleaning Your Inbox

7.1 Searching and filtering

At the top of the sender list you will find:

- **Search box** — type any part of a name or email address to narrow the list
- **Category filter** — choose a category from the left panel to show only senders in that group

7.2 Trashing a sender's emails

- 1 Find the row you want to clean up and click the **Trash** button.
- 2 A confirmation box will appear showing the sender name and category. Check both to make sure you have the right row.
- 3 **Optional:** Use the “Only emails older than” dropdown to protect recent messages. For example, choosing **1 year** will move emails older than one year to Trash while keeping everything from the past twelve months.
- 4 Click **Move to Trash** to confirm. The button will show a live count (for example, **45 / 312...**) while Ciela works through the emails.
- 5 When finished, the row disappears from the list. Other rows from the same sender are not affected.

Trash, not Delete. Ciela never permanently deletes email. All emails are moved to your provider's Trash folder — Gmail uses Trash, Outlook uses Deleted Items, iCloud uses Deleted Messages. Your provider keeps items there for 30 days before removing them automatically. If you change your mind, open your inbox in a browser, go to the Trash or Deleted Items folder, and restore individual emails before the 30 days are up.

7.3 Undo

Changed your mind? Click the **Trash History** tab in the top navigation bar. It shows a log of all trash operations from the past 24 hours, with an **Undo** button for each. Click Undo to move those emails back to your inbox immediately.

7.4 Keeping some emails from a sender

Sort & protect lets you review every email type a sender has used, choose which types to keep, and trash the rest in one step.

In this checklist, you tick the types you want to KEEP — not the types you want to delete. Everything you leave unticked will be trashed. Read each row carefully before confirming.

- 1 Click the sender's **display name** to open the detail screen.
- 2 Click **Sort & protect**.
- 3 A checklist appears. Each row shows an example subject line, the number of emails in that group, and how recently the last one arrived.
- 4 **Tick every type you want to keep.** Leave unticked the types you are happy to remove.
- 5 Click the **Trash N emails from N groups** button to move the unticked emails to Trash.

7.5 Bulk category cleaning

For categories designed for mass cleanup (Active Marketing, Dead Marketing, Subscription, Notifications), a **Clean all** button appears at the top of the category view.

- If no sender in the category was opened in the last 90 days, a single confirmation window appears and the clean proceeds immediately.
- If any sender was recently opened, an **Outlier Review** screen appears first. Review those senders, protect any you want to keep, and the clean proceeds on everything else.

7.6 Recommended cleaning order

If you are not sure where to start, this order tends to work well:

1. Filter to **Dead Marketing** first — these are the safest to remove. Trash all of them using “All time.”
2. Move to **Active Marketing** and trash senders you no longer want to hear from.
3. Review **Subscription** — unsubscribe from newsletters you want to stop, then trash the backlog.
4. Leave **Personal**, **Security**, **Finance**, **Travel**, and **Receipts** alone unless you are certain you no longer need a specific sender's history.

8 Smart Purge Tray

After a scan, Ciela may surface a **Smart Purge Tray** — a panel showing senders that have kept filling your inbox across multiple scans despite previous cleanups. These are the ones that keep coming back.

The tray lets you clean all flagged senders at once or dismiss individual entries. It only appears when Ciela has enough scan history to identify genuine repeat senders.

9 Auto-Clean Rules

Auto-Clean Rules let Ciela trash certain senders automatically on every rescan, without you having to do it manually each time.

9.1 Creating a rule

After cleaning the same sender or category three times, Ciela will offer to create a rule automatically. You can also create rules manually from Settings → Auto-Clean Rules.

Each rule specifies:

- A sender address or category
- An age filter (for example, “older than 6 months”)
- Whether to also attempt to unsubscribe

9.2 Managing rules

Open **Settings** and look for the **Auto-Clean Rules** section. Each rule shows the sender or category, the age threshold, and when it last ran. You can toggle rules on and off, or delete them, at any time.

Rules run at the end of each rescan. They only apply to emails that arrive after the rule is created — they do not reach back into your existing inbox.

10 Scan History

The **Scan History** tab in the top navigation bar shows a table of every scan you have run, with the date and the number of emails scanned.

Click any row to open a **Scan Report** for that scan. The report shows:

- A snapshot of your inbox size at the time of the scan
- Category changes — how many emails were added or removed in each category since the previous scan
- A full cleanup history for that scan period, with **Undo** buttons for operations that are still within 24 hours

11 Outlook Filters

If you are connected to an Outlook account, Ciela can create **inbox rules** in your Outlook account directly — these apply on Microsoft's side, so they work on every device where you check Outlook, not just Ciela.

Outlook Filter suggestions appear in **Settings → Your Outlook Filters**. Each suggestion is based on senders Ciela has identified as safe to auto-clean. You can review the suggested rule, confirm it, and Ciela will create it in your Outlook account automatically.

Active Outlook Filters are listed with a toggle to enable or disable each one. Deleting a filter in Ciela also removes it from your Outlook account.

12 Multiple Accounts

Ciela supports connecting multiple email accounts across providers. Each account is scanned and stored separately — their sender lists do not mix.

12.1 Adding an account

- 1 Open **Settings** and click **Add Account**.
- 2 Choose your provider and follow the connect flow for that provider (see Section 3).
- 3 Once connected, a new account pill appears in the top navigation bar. Click it to switch to that inbox.

12.2 Removing an account

Open **Settings**, select the account you want to remove, and click **Disconnect**. This removes the account from Ciela and clears its local data. Your emails remain in your inbox — nothing is deleted from your provider.

13 Disconnecting and Rescanning

13.1 Disconnecting

Click **Disconnect** in Settings to sign out and return to the connect screen. Your scan results are saved locally — the next time you connect, your inbox list reappears immediately while a fresh scan runs in the background.

13.2 Rescanning

Click **Rescan** in the top-right corner to check for new mail. Ciela only fetches emails that arrived since your last scan, so this typically completes in seconds to a few minutes. Your existing results are merged with any new senders found.

For a full fresh start, click the small arrow next to the Rescan button and choose **Full rescan**. This re-reads your entire inbox from the beginning and replaces all results. Use this if your counts look wrong or you want to start completely fresh.

14 Frequently Asked Questions

14.1 Getting started

Which option do I choose — Gmail, Outlook, or IMAP?

If your email address ends in gmail.com, choose Gmail. If it ends in outlook.com, hotmail.com, or live.com, choose Outlook. For icloud.com, yahoo.com, aol.com, zoho.com, fastmail.com, or anything else, choose IMAP.

What is an app password and why do I need one?

Email providers like iCloud and Yahoo do not allow third-party apps to use your main account password directly — they require you to generate a special one-time password just for that app. This app password only lets Ciela read your inbox; it does not give access to your Apple ID, your payment information, or anything else. You can revoke it at any time from your provider's security settings without affecting your main password or other apps.

How do I generate an app password for iCloud?

Sign in to appleid.apple.com, go to Sign-In and Security → App-Specific Passwords, and click the + button to generate a new one. Two-factor authentication must be enabled on your Apple ID before this option appears. If you do not see it, enable two-factor authentication first.

How do I generate an app password for Yahoo?

Sign in to Yahoo Mail, click your name in the top right corner, go to Account Security, and look for “Generate app password.” Select “Other app,” type “Ciela,” and click Generate.

How do I enable IMAP in Zoho Mail?

IMAP is disabled by default in Zoho. Sign in to Zoho Mail in your browser, go to Settings → Mail Accounts → IMAP Access, and turn it on. Then come back to Ciela and connect.

My IMAP connection keeps failing. What should I check?

Work through this list in order:

- Make sure you are entering your **app password**, not your main account password. These are different.
- For iCloud: check that two-factor authentication is enabled on your Apple ID, and that you generated the app password after enabling it.
- For Zoho: confirm that IMAP access is turned on (see the question above).
- For any provider: try generating a new app password. Old ones sometimes stop working.
- If none of the above helps, check your provider's help pages for “IMAP access” — some accounts need an extra setting enabled.

My browser did not open during Gmail or Outlook sign-in. What do I do?

Make sure a default browser is set in your system settings. If a browser opened but nothing happened, try signing in to your provider manually in your browser first, then return to Ciela and try connecting again.

14.2 Scanning

How long will my first scan take?

It depends on your provider and how many emails you have. Gmail and Outlook are the fastest — a 100,000-email inbox typically takes 10–20 minutes. IMAP providers (iCloud, Yahoo, etc.) are slower — expect 30–60 minutes for a very large IMAP inbox. You can leave Ciela running in the background while you do other things.

Can I stop a scan and come back to it?

Yes. You can close Ciela at any time. When you reopen it, the scan will resume from exactly where it stopped — it does not start over.

Can I leave my computer while the scan is running? What if it goes to sleep?

You can leave the app running while you do other things, but keep your computer awake. If the computer goes to sleep and cuts the network connection, Ciela will pause and resume when the connection comes back. If the app is closed mid-scan, it will resume from the last checkpoint when you reopen it.

The numbers in Ciela don't match what my inbox shows. Is something wrong?

This is normal. Your inbox total in Gmail, Outlook, or iCloud includes your Spam folder and Trash, which Ciela does not scan. Ciela also only counts emails in your main inbox — not in folders, labels, or archives depending on your provider's setup. The numbers will never match exactly, but the senders Ciela finds are the ones that have been emailing you.

I connected an IMAP account but the scan seems slow. Is that normal?

Yes. IMAP has protocol constraints that make scanning slower than Gmail or Outlook. A very large IMAP inbox (100,000+ emails) can take an hour or more on a first scan. Subsequent rescans are much faster because they only check new mail.

14.3 Understanding your results

Why does the same company appear in two rows?

Some senders use one email address to send multiple types of email — for example, order confirmations and promotional offers. Ciela separates these into distinct rows so you can remove the marketing without affecting your receipts. Each row is independently actionable.

What does “Unknown” mean? Do I need to do something about it?

Unknown means Ciela could not confidently place the sender into one of the named categories. It is not an error — it just means the sender did not match any known pattern. You can leave Unknown senders alone, or click the category badge next to any of them and move them to the right category yourself. Ciela will remember the correction.

What does “Protected” mean? How do I remove protection?

A protected sender is one you have manually marked as untouchable — it will not be included in any bulk cleanup operation. To remove protection, open the sender’s detail screen by clicking their display name, and click **Protect** again to toggle it off.

A sender shows thousands of emails. Is that right?

Probably yes. A daily marketing email from a company you subscribed to ten years ago adds up to 3,650 emails. The counts are real — that is what makes a cleanup so satisfying. If a number seems truly implausible (for example, millions of emails from a single sender), use the **Full Rescan** option to refresh all counts from scratch.

14.4 Cleaning

Will Ciela delete my emails permanently?

No. Ciela only moves emails to your provider’s Trash folder — Gmail uses Trash, Outlook uses Deleted Items, iCloud uses Deleted Messages. Your provider keeps items there for 30 days before permanently removing them. You can restore emails from Trash in your inbox at any time during those 30 days.

I accidentally trashed something I wanted to keep. Can I get it back?

Yes, if it was within the last 24 hours. Click the **Trash History** tab in the top navigation bar, find the operation, and click **Undo**. The emails will be moved back to your inbox immediately. If more than 24 hours have passed, open your inbox in a browser, go to the Trash or Deleted Items folder, and restore the emails from there — you have up to 30 days before your provider removes them permanently.

I trashed a sender but they’re still showing in my inbox. Why?

The trash operation completed, but the sender row will disappear on your next rescan. Click **Rescan** in the top right to refresh your sender list. The row will be gone once Ciela confirms no remaining emails from that sender.

Is it safe to trash Security or Finance emails?

Be careful with these categories. Login alerts and bank statements can be useful for reference — especially for tax purposes. We recommend keeping Finance and Security emails unless you are certain you no longer need a specific sender’s history. If you do want to clear old records, use the “Older than 1 year” or “Older than 5 years” date filter rather than “All time.”

What if an email is in the wrong category?

Click the category badge next to the sender name and choose the correct category from the dropdown. Ciela will remember the correction across all future scans. You can also reclassify from inside the sender detail screen.

14.5 Using Ciela

Can I connect more than one email account?

Yes. Open Settings and click **Add Account** to connect a second inbox. Each account is stored and displayed separately. You switch between them using the account pill in the top navigation bar.

What does Full Rescan do? When should I use it?

A regular rescan only fetches emails that arrived since your last scan — it is fast. A Full Rescan re-reads your entire inbox from the beginning and rebuilds all counts from scratch. Use it if your numbers look wrong, if you have made a lot of changes in your inbox outside of Ciela, or after a long gap between uses.

What happens if I disconnect from Ciela? Will my emails be deleted?

No. Disconnecting just signs you out of the app — it removes Ciela's local copy of your scan results and clears the sign-in. Your actual emails remain completely untouched in your inbox. Nothing is deleted from your provider.

Can I use Ciela on my phone or tablet?

Not yet. Ciela is a desktop app for Windows, Mac, and Linux. A mobile version is not currently available.

15 A Note on Privacy

Ciela was built on a simple belief: your email is yours.

Most inbox-cleaning services work by connecting your account to their own servers, where your email is read, indexed, and in some cases used to build a profile of you. Ciela does none of this.

Every email is fetched directly from your provider to your computer. The classification runs on your computer. The results are stored in an encrypted local database on your computer — nothing is persisted to a remote server, because there is no remote server.

The only things Ciela ever sends over the network are:

- The sign-in token that proves to Gmail or Outlook you have given permission — the same thing any email app sends
- The IMAP app password, sent directly to your provider's server over an encrypted connection — never to Ciela's servers (there are none)
- The API requests to list and fetch your email metadata from your provider

That is it.